

Azure AI Search vs SQL Server 2025 Hyperscale

Native vector + semantic search comparison · cost crossover model · migration map · East US pricing, May 2026

Azure AI Search — per Search Unit (East US, May 2026)

TIER	\$/SU/HR	\$/SU/MO (730 HR)	STORAGE / PARTITION	MAX PARTITIONS	MAX SUS / SERVICE
Basic	\$0.101	\$73.73	15 GB	3	9
Standard S1	\$0.336	\$245.28	160 GB	12	36
Standard S2	\$1.344	\$981.12	512 GB	12	36
Standard S3	\$2.688	\$1,962.24	1 TB	12	36
Storage Opt L1	\$3.839	\$2,802.47	2 TB	12	36
Storage Opt L2	\$7.677	\$5,604.21	4 TB	12	36

SU = partitions × replicas. Service-wide cap is 36 SUs (so with 4 replicas, the maximum partition count is 9 — bumping partitions further requires upgrading the tier). **Azure AI Search does not offer reserved capacity / 1-yr or 3-yr commitment pricing** — all billing is hourly PAYG.

Vector index size cap per partition (separate from data storage cap): Basic 5 GB, S1 35 GB, S2 150 GB, S3 / L2 300 GB, L1 150 GB.

Add-ons

METER	PRICE
Semantic ranker (Standard tier)	\$1.00 / 1 000 queries
Semantic ranker (Free tier)	First 1 000 queries / mo free

Document cracking — image extraction

\$1.00 / 1 000 (volume discounts apply)

Agentic retrieval — medium reasoning

\$0.0001 / 1 000 tokens

Azure SQL Database Hyperscale (East US, May 2026)

COMPUTE SERIES	\$/VCORE/HR (PAYG)	1-YR RESERVED	3-YR RESERVED
Standard-series Gen5	\$0.18266	~\$0.1187	~\$0.0822
Premium-series	\$0.18266	~\$0.1187	~\$0.0822
Premium-series Memory-Optimized	\$0.25572	~\$0.1663	~\$0.1150
DC-series (confidential)	\$0.36500	\$0.2374	\$0.1644

Each HA replica and named replica is billed at the same compute rate as the primary. Reserved capacity discounts are approximate (~35% for 1-yr, ~55% for 3-yr).

Storage & backup

METER	PRICE
Hyperscale data storage (Single DB)	\$0.10 / GB / month
Hyperscale data storage (Elastic Pool)	\$0.25 / GB / month
Hyperscale I/O	\$0.20 / 1 M I/O ops
Backup storage (LRS / ZRS short-term)	Included up to 100% of DB size
LTR backup (LRS / ZRS)	\$0.025 / GB / month

LTR backup (RA-GRS / RA-GZRS)

\$0.05 / GB / month

Source: Azure Retail Prices API (prices.azure.com/api/retail/prices), East US region, retrieved May 20, 2026.